



reconvene,” was the reply.

We were thinking that the client would not give us names of the competing websites, stating confidentiality, and it could be a negotiation tactic of theirs to derive more juice from us. But we were wrong.

After four hours, we reconvened. The client had shared the names of the two websites. We also got to know that one was reporting 8x of our CTR and the other 10x.

The head of our Digital Marketing Services team had also joined us this time.

“Err, what’s their average-time-per-user as per Alexa or SEMrush?”

“First one has 52 seconds and second’s is 1.1 minutes.”

“What’s ours?”

“28.4 minutes.”

“So, users are spending 20 times more time on our website but clicking the same banner on their websites 10 times more?”

“Yes, it seems like that.”

“Strangely, their web banner on all websites has body text that’s not readable. Why would it be receiving such a high CTR?”

Since, we had no means of getting the ‘real’ answer to that question, a colleague proposed that we turn the question on its head.

“If we were to provide a higher CTR to this client, is there a way we can GAME the system?”

Silence again.

Then, someone asked, what if we simply shared a report with higher number of clicks and CTR? How will the client know the correct figures?

“In what format is the report shared with the client?”

“It’s a presentation sent in a PDF format.”

“Does it have a screenshot of the Google Analytics report?”

“Yes, it does.”

“Can it be photo-shopped?”

“Sure, any document can be.”

“Is the client using a UTM code



here through which they can track the actual clicks?”

“No, not in this case.”

“That’s good. Does our contract allow the client to audit and view our Google Analytics reports in real time?”

“No, we have never pitched an option like that.”

“Ok, great. So, we got one answer for sure. Any other?”

“Check out this other website. They have placed their web banner at a location where anyone using a mobile will accidentally click on the banner.”

“Can we place their banner on such a position too?”

“Yes, that can be done.”

“Did the client book a specific position?”

“Yes, they did, but since this looks like a more premium position, we can propose it as a special privilege to them as a *token of thanks* to the large volume of business given by them.”

“I’m sure they will be happy to get a more visible position and higher number of clicks, even if they are accidental ones.”

“Great, we got another option now. Can we come up with more?”

“What if we got a few trainees

to install a tool that changes their IP dynamically at the click of a button, and after every change they clicked on the client’s web banners? They will all get registered as clicks by unique users – right?”

“Interesting! Yes, this could work even if they had a UTM tracker.”

“Three options! We’re really thinking out of the box now! Can we figure out more?”

“How about trying one of the bots to change IP and click on their banner ads?”

“Can we?”

“Just spoke to the IT team, and they believe it’s possible. They will need a couple of days to check and confirm, and then they will share the approximate cost for such a bot.”

“Hurray! We now have four options. Can there be more?”

“There are websites to whom if you pay, they generate clicks for you!”

“Why pay them when we can hire trainees?”

“The legal liability on us gets reduced, because now they are doing the *hanky-panky*, not us. We have only paid them to promote our link. Plus, they really do a professional job to make it look like genuine traf-